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| **Original name** | - | Vardhamana |
| **Place of Birth** | - | Kundhagrama near Vaishali, Bihar |
| **Parents** | - | Siddharth, Trishala |
| **Place of Death** | - | Pavapuri, Bihar |

prominence under the aegis of Mahavira, during the sixth century BC (BCE).

DO YOU KNOW?

The word **Jain** derives from the Sanskrit word Jina, which means conquering self and the external world.

## Mahavira (The Great Hero)

Vardhamana, meaning 'prosperous', was a kshatriya prince. However, at the age of 30, he renounced his princely status to adopt an ascetic life. He undertook intense meditation.

After twelve and a half years of rigorous penance, Vardhamana attained omniscience or supreme knowledge, known as *Kevala*.

**Omniscience** – It is the ability to know everything or be infinitely wise.

Thereafter, he became Jina meaning 'one who conquered worldly pleasure and attachment'. His followers are called Jains. Mahavira reviewed the ancient Sramanic traditions and came up with new doctrines. Therefore he is believed to be the real founder of Jainism.

## Unique Teachings of Jainism

- Jainism denies God as the creator of Universe.
- Basic philosophy of Jainism is Ahimsa or 'non –Violence'.
- Ultimate aim of Jainism is attaining moksha or ending the cycle of birth – death – rebirth.
- Jains reject the belief in Last judgement, where God, a supreme being, decides who goes to heaven or hell.
- Jainism advocates that the goodness or quality of one's life is determined by one's karma.

DO YOU KNOW?

**What is Karma?**

The belief that a person's actions in this life determine the quality of his or her later part of the current life and the next incarnation.

## Tri–rathnas or Three Jewels

Mahavira exhorted the three – fold path for the attainment of moksha and for the liberation from Karma.

They are:

- Right Faith
- Right Knowledge
- Right action

**Moksha** - Liberation from the cycle of birth and death



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